

CHAPTER FIVE

The Toolkit

(A Strand Chapter – read this one slowly.)

Hi, friend. This chapter is a little different. Step out of the story for a minute. I want to talk to you directly.

Most chapters in this book are about the kids. This chapter is about you.

You have, somewhere inside you, what I want to call a toolkit. The toolkit is the set of things you do, when something hard is happening, to make yourself feel less hard. Some of these things you have always done without thinking. You go to your room. You squeeze a pillow. You play a video game. You eat a snack. You cry. You ride your bike very fast around the block. You text your best friend.

Some of these things are good for you. Some of them are not. Most kids have a mix. Most adults also have a mix, which is one of the reasons adults sometimes look so tired.

The point of this chapter is — and I am going to say it once and you can think about it for as long as you want —

You can build the toolkit on purpose.

You do not have to just have whatever happens to have ended up in your toolkit. You can put things in. You can take things out. You can swap things out for better things.

Sofia, in our story, has been doing this for two years. She figured out, on her own, that her stomach hurts when she is scared. She figured out that if she puts her hand on her

stomach and breathes slowly, the hurt is smaller. She figured out that if she names what she is scared of, the scared-ness gets quieter. She figured out that if she writes the scared thing down on a piece of paper, sometimes the paper carries some of the weight for her.

Each of these things — the hand on the stomach, the slow breath, the naming, the writing — is a tool. Sofia has been collecting tools for two years. She did not know she was collecting them. She just kept doing what worked.

I want to give you, in this chapter, a list of tools that you can try. Not all of them will work for you. Some of them will. You will not know which ones until you try them. Some of them will work some days and not others. That is normal.

Read through them. Try a few. Build your own toolkit.

THE TOOLKIT — TEN TOOLS TO TRY

1. The Slow Breath. Breathe in for four counts. Hold for one. Breathe out for six counts. Do this five times. This is the oldest tool in the world. People have been using it for thousands of years. There is a reason.

2. The Hand-on-Heart. Put your hand on your chest, over your heart. Press a little. Say to yourself, *I am here. I am okay. This will pass.* You can say it in your head. The hand and the words go together.

3. The Five Senses Walk. Look around. Name five things you can see. Four things you can touch. Three things you can hear. Two things you can smell. One thing you can taste. This pulls your brain out of the worry-loop. Your brain cannot worry-loop and notice the world at the same time.

4. The Tell-Somebody. Tell a trusted person what is going on. Just naming it out loud to another person, who is on your side, makes it about thirty percent smaller. Sometimes more.

5. The Write-It-Down. Open a notebook. Write what you are feeling. You do not have to write neatly. You do not have to write in sentences. You can scribble. You can draw. The point is to get the feeling out of your head and onto the page, where it can sit and be looked at.

6. The Move-the-Body. Run around the block. Jump rope. Do twenty jumping jacks. Push against a wall as hard as you can for ten seconds. Big feelings live in the body. Sometimes the way out of them is through the body, not through the head.

7. The Three Other Reasons. This one is from Book One. When somebody does something that bothers you, before you decide why they did it, come up with three other reasons it could be. Pick the kindest reason. Move on. We are going to come back to this one a lot.

8. The Future-Me Letter. Write a quick letter to yourself a year from now. Tell future-you what is going on. Future-you will read it and be glad. Past-you will feel less alone, because you remembered that future-you exists.

9. The One-Question Pause. Before you react to anything that has just happened, ask yourself one question: *What do I actually need right now?* Then answer the question. Sometimes the answer is a snack. Sometimes the answer is a hug. Sometimes the answer is to go to my room for ten minutes. Whatever it is — name it.

10. The Trusted Adult. When the toolkit is not enough — and sometimes it is not enough — you tell a trusted adult. The trusted adult is part of the toolkit. The trusted adult is not a failure tool. The trusted adult is the biggest tool. The biggest tool is for the hardest things. That is what trusted adults are for.

You can copy this list. You can put it on the wall by your bed. You can fold it into your pencil case. You can ignore it. You can come back to it. But here is what I want you to remember.

The toolkit is real. It works. Adults use it. Therapists teach it. Athletes use it. Surgeons use it. Astronauts use it. There is nothing magic about it. There is nothing childish about it. Building your toolkit on purpose is one of the most grown-up things a person can do.

You are starting now. You are starting young. You are going to be very, very good at this by the time you are an adult.

The kids in our story are starting too. Some of them already have a few tools. Some of them are just beginning. You are right there with them.

Okay. End of the chapter. Step back into the story. We have a lot more to do.

— J.A.R.